

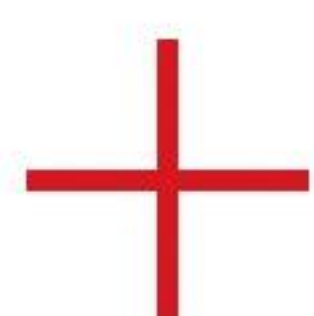
"Coco Gauff is one of the best competitors you'll see in any sport, anywhere," said Paul Annacone, who coached all-time greats Pete Sampras and Roger Federer. Unfortunately, she has had to rely on that critical asset far too often this season. Gauff is 11-9 after losing the first set. Part of her struggles stem from her unreliable serve — only 132 aces against a tour-leading 279 double faults. Gauff's forehand can also break down on occasion, leading to tactical confusion and questionable shot selection. The latter was exemplified when Gauff blew a match point with a forehand drop shot into the net at 9-8 in the match tiebreak of her 6-2, 1-6, 7-6(12-10) semifinal loss to Muchova at Wimbledon. The 22-year-old American won her first Major at the 2023 US Open. This year, her semifinal showing at the Canadian Open, where she lost in three sets to Rybakina, heartened her. "I think I'm making the right decisions about the necessary adjustments to my tennis," Gauff said. "I am confident that they will bear fruit, and that is why I will continue to work with great conviction." And, sure enough, she backed it up by winning the Cincinnati Open.

COCO GAUFF

No. 4



Prediction: Semifinals



Bonus quarterfinal pick

Iga Swiatek, No. 5

The six-time Major champion can salvage a forgettable season with a second US Open crown, and she's peaking at the right time. Swiatek won her first title at the Canadian Open, where she whipped Kostyuk, Shnaider, Svitolina, and, most impressively, Rybakina in a 6-2, 6-3 final.

Highly motivated but lacking the versatility to complement her nonpareil forehand, Swiatek will match her quarterfinal showings of the past two years.

After 19-year-old Mirra Andreeva trounced Kostyuk 6-1, 6-3 in the French Open semifinals, former No. 1 Caroline Wozniacki echoed the tennis cognoscenti who touted her as a can't-miss future champion.

With the crowd rooting for huge underdog Chwalinska in the final, the sometimes-temperamental Andreeva kept her cool against the tricky Polish shot-maker to prevail 6-3, 6-2 and become the youngest Roland Garros champion since Monica Seles in 1992.

While clay has proved her most successful surface this season, Andreeva excelled on hard courts last year. She won Indian Wells, beating Sabalenka, Swiatek, Svitolina, and Rybakina, and Dubai, ousting Rybakina and Swiatek. The talented, versatile Andreeva will reproduce that hard-court prowess in New York.

**MIRRA
ANDREEVA**

No. 6

Prediction: Semifinals

